

What is Authentication Strength?

Authentication Strength is a security policy in Microsoft Entra ID that defines **which authentication methods are allowed** to access a resource.

Simple Definition

Authentication Strength = A set of approved authentication methods that users must use to sign in.

Real-Life Analogy

Imagine an office building.

Authentication Method = Your ID

You may have:

- Employee ID Card
- Fingerprint
- Face Recognition
- Security Key

These are different ways to prove who you are.

Authentication Strength = Building Security Rule

The building manager says:

Normal Office Area

- Employee Card OR Fingerprint

Data Center

- Fingerprint ONLY

CEO Room

- Fingerprint + Security Key

The rule defining what is accepted is the **Authentication Strength**.

Microsoft Entra Example

Authentication Methods Available

A user has:

- Password + Authenticator Push
 - SMS OTP
 - FIDO2 Security Key
 - Windows Hello
-

Authentication Strength: Multifactor Authentication

Allowed:

- ☒ Password + Authenticator Push
- ☒ SMS OTP
- ☒ FIDO2
- ☒ Windows Hello

Result:

User can use **any** of these methods.

Authentication Strength: Passwordless MFA

Allowed:

- ☒ FIDO2
- ☒ Windows Hello
- ☒ Authenticator Phone Sign-in

Not Allowed:

- ☒ Password + Push
 - ☒ SMS
-

Authentication Strength: Phishing-Resistant MFA

Allowed:

- ✅ FIDO2 Security Key
- ✅ Windows Hello for Business
- ✅ Certificate-Based Authentication

Not Allowed:

- ❌ SMS
- ❌ Password + Push
- ❌ Email OTP

Technical Flow

```
User
|
v
Authentication Method
(Password + Push, FIDO2, Hello)
|
v
Authentication Strength Policy
(Check if method is allowed)
|
v
Access Granted / Denied
```



Practical SC-300 Example

Scenario

Finance Application contains salary data.

Conditional Access Policy:

```
Require Authentication Strength:
Phishing-Resistant MFA
```



User 1

Uses:

Password + Authenticator Push



Result:

✗ Denied

Reason:

Method is MFA but not phishing-resistant.

User 2

Uses:

FIDO2 Security Key



Result:

✓ Allowed

Reason:

FIDO2 is included in the required Authentication Strength.

Easy Formula for Exams

Authentication Method

=

How the user signs in

Authentication Strength

=

Which sign-in methods the policy accepts



One-Line Example

- **Method** = Password + Authenticator Push
- **Strength** = "Only Passwordless MFA Allowed"

Result:

✗ Access Denied because the method does not meet the required strength.

That's the entire concept of **Authentication Strength** in Microsoft Entra ID. It is simply a

security level that determines which authentication methods are acceptable for access.